The energy levels didn’t drop till the last day of the campaign. Denied permission to hold a rally in Varanasi by the district administration, Modi embarked on a successful roadshow through the city’s streets on 8 May. Buoyed by the response, the BJP’s media team sensed an opportunity for a fresh campaign film. Within twenty-four hours, a film with shots of Modi in Varanasi was readied—it was fine-tuned at least a couple of times—and aired continuously till the moment the campaign officially ended.

It is this intensity which was missing in the Congress advertising campaign. I had seen shades of it in 2004 when Jairam Ramesh and a small team had developed the ‘Aam Aadmi’ slogan. Then, perhaps, the Congress had nothing to lose. I had witnessed it again in 2009 when the Congress successfully stuck to its ‘aam aadmi’ theme. In 2014, the Congress didn’t have a big idea nor the hunger to execute it.

The ‘aam aadmi’ patent was no longer with the Congress. Kejriwal’s party had usurped, almost ‘stolen’ it, and built their own political model around it. Moreover, with price rise hurting the common man, the ‘aam aadmi’ tag was never going to win hearts. ‘We needed something different, a concept that would stand out in comparison with the competition,’ is how one Congress leader puts it.

The BJP campaign was Modi-centric. The Congress decided early enough that while Rahul would be the face of the campaign, the slogans would suggest that a party and the country were above any individual. The Congress theme tried to capture the idea of an ‘inclusive’ India. That’s how the original tag lines were conceived—‘Main Nahin, Hum’ (Not Me, Us), ‘*Tode Nahi, Jode*’ (Unite, not Divide) and the umbrella concept of ‘*Har Haath Shakti, Har Haath Tarakki*’ (Strength and Progress for All). The posters had Rahul in the middle, surrounded by anonymous faces, dressed so as to denote ethnic origins—Muslim girl in a headscarf, Sikh boy in a turban, an Adivasi in a dhoti. It clearly lacked originality. ‘We wanted to show that the BJP was about a divisive personality cult, while we stood for every Indian,’ is how Jairam Ramesh describes it.

One of those Indians featured in a Congress advertisement was a young party activist from Goa, Hasiba Amin. The president of the Goa unit of the